relationship with the US. He particularly saw Beijing's continued imprisonment of Americans as "extraordinarily foolish." Nehru wondered if the Chinese leadership really wanted the Sino-US relationship to progress since the US had long made it clear that no change was possible without the release of the prisoners. On the other side, the Indian prime minister had detected—even from the hawkish Dulles—a desire, even "anxious[ness]" to improve Sino-US relations.[205] US nonrecognition of China did continue to frustrate Delhi; it meant that China would not owe any "obligations" to the international community—this, Nehru told Commonwealth leaders, was "dangerous." Furthermore, it kept China in Soviet arms. Nonetheless, he believed Americans' "practical instincts" would slowly lead them to "the facts of the situation."[206]

As far as Delhi was concerned, while Beijing's overall attitude seemed to be increasingly rigid and intolerant of differences with other countries, Washington's approach continued to show improvement. By early 1958, US officials were commenting on the "harmonious" nature of the relationship over the recent period.[207] Later that year, analysts noted that—privately, at least—Nehru seemed to be "somewhat more sympathetic" to the US.[208]

Dealing with Differences

US-India differences, even on China, had not disappeared, but the two governments worked toward handling them more effectively. This was evident in their reaction to the second Taiwan Strait crisis in 1958. In the second half of August, China began shelling the offshore islands again and subsequently tried to blockade Taiwan. The Eisenhower administration believed that the loss of the islands would adversely affect Jiang's government and Taiwanese security, and, in turn, that would damage US credibility and interests. The American aim during the crisis was both to support and to restrain Taipei. By backing Taipei with military assets and public declarations of support, Washington tried to pressure Beijing to back down. But it also resumed the direct Sino-US channel, this time in Warsaw. By mid-September the US was convinced that the crisis had de-escalated. By the end of the month, the Chinese blockade ended. American attempts to convince Jiang to withdraw from the offshore islands, however, were less successful. Eventually there was a ceasefire in early October.[209]